

THE MAIL RUN... TAUPO TO NAPIER...16th March 2002

Friday morning, loaded up the old 350 (Ariel of course) onto the trailer and hooked up to my support crew's '54 Dodge and off to Taupo. Arrived there mid afternoon and checked in to the Taupo Motor Camp. We set up our cabin and unloaded the bike. By this time others started to arrive along with the Tauranga contingent. We headed up town on foot, checked things out etc and finished up at the local Cossie Club where we quenched our thirst and had a good meal. My mates wouldn't let me drink too much, reckoned I'd have to be fit for the next day, but I snuck an extra one or two in when they weren't looking.

On waking up Saturday morning the camp seemed to be overrun with bikes of all makes and sizes. Mine started to look pretty scruffy alongside some of the shiny restored ones but I was confident that looks weren't everything! Soon most everyone was starting up or warming up their machines. Harry Strang came and asked me if I was going to start mine and I just said I don't want to wear it out as I knew it would start when we were ready! (Which it did.)

Shortly after 9 am we were handed our start packs which contained a nice sash with HBCMC Mailrun 2002 Taupo-Napier printed on it and a certificate to say we were participating in the event, and our lunch and dinner tickets. After a short briefing we all departed to De Bretts parking area on the Napier highway. Here an official speech was made by the Mayor of Taupo and the handing over of the official mail bag. It had been brought up in a beautiful horse and gig from the boat harbour where it had arrived by the steamship "Alice". From here we set off at approximately 1 minute intervals, 35 of us. On the first lot of flat going I was passed by a couple of Indians, I thought this is not too good so I sort of let them go, but as soon as we had a bit of an uphill I found I had the legs on them and soon passed them giving them a big wave.

The first stop is at the Rangataiki tearooms. Everyone cruised in, some had a cup of tea etc and a good old yak. Soon off to lunch at the Tarawera Pub where the HBCMC had a BBQ going and were making hamburgers which were really great as I was starting to get hungry by this time. A lot of good banter going on amongst different ones all the time. The Indian guys giving me heaps about heading them off on the hills! Barrie Alderdice was having trouble with a badly leaking fuel tap, but with a bit of help and him holding his finger over the tank outlet while someone tightened the cork seal. The screw had worked loose so he soon had that fixed!

Off again, a short stop at Te Pohue Pub for water etc for some. It was not long before we were all downhill to the Esk Valley and on into Napier where we all gathered in the parking area on Marine Parade. The mail bag was handed over to the Napier's Mayor's representative. The mail bag had been carried over on a big Harley D and side car. It was quite a sight with all the bikes lined up together, especially all the Ariels together, 9 of them, we were the largest of the Marques with the Indians next with 4 or 5. The weather for the trip was excellent, brilliant sunshine all the way and hardly any wind. A great day to ride old motorbikes, or any motor bike.

Soon off to Kennedy Park and set up our digs for the night, a clean up and off to the Napier Cossie Club to wash the trail dust down. It was here the evening prizegiving was held with an excellent dinner provided. Harry S won the prize for the best restored bike with his 1955 500 Ariel. Grant Antram was given a special prize for riding his James all the way without a hitch. Everyone got a prize of some sort but it was really good to see the TCMCC being so well represented. Those present were Harry Strang Ariel, Lloyd Baker Ariel, Barrie Alderdice Ariel, Shirley Alderdice Car, Len Parry Ariel, Allan Watson Ariel, Jim Strang Ariel, Bill Hutchinson Vincent, Grant Antram James.

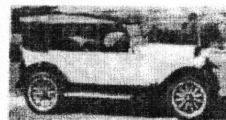
After a few more beers the Cossie Club courtesy bus transported us back to our accomodation. To wind up the weekend was a chorus of TCMCC members singing Happy Birthday to Barrie in his car as he was about to depart for home. Speaking for myself, a great weekend and I'll be back next year!!!

"WATTIE"



S S Waimarie

Commemorative Re-enactment
Of



Vintage Car

Royal Mail Run

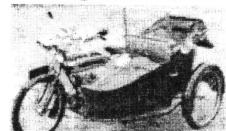
Wanganui to Napier

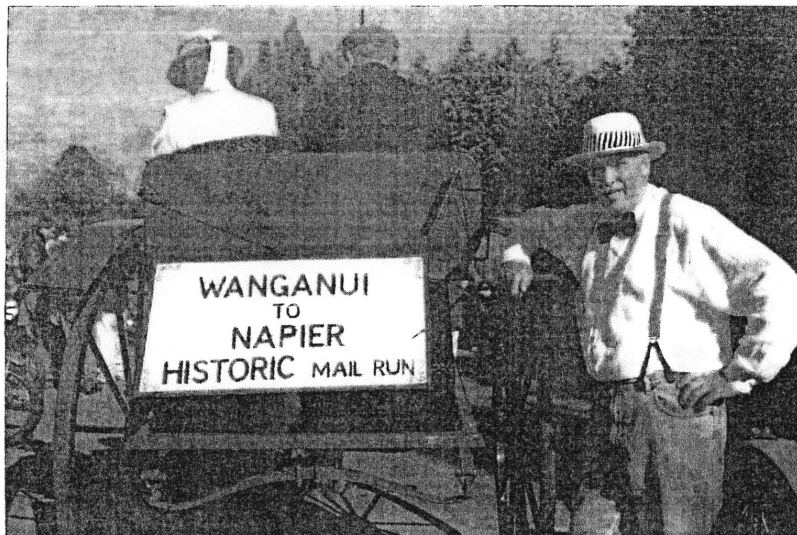
9th March 2002

S S Alice



Vintage Motorcycle





HAPPY CHAPPY: Tom Waterland, engineer and steam enthusiast waiting for the final handover of the mail bag from horse and cart to the vintage motorcycle and sidecar for the journey across the Napier-Taupo highway. Photos: Sam Ryan

Mail gets through the old-fashioned way

by Sue Hawkins

Lake Taupo's historic steamboat Alice played a pivotal role in the re-enactment of a 19th century mail run which was completed on Saturday.

Back in the 19th century it took three weeks to carry the mail from Wanganui to Napier, and part of the voyage included a leg crossing Lake Taupo from Tokaanu to Taupo.

The re-enactment has involved steam enthusiast and engineer Tom Waterland who, as a co-owner of the 123-year-old Alice, was keen to have the craft show her style.

The postal run began at Wanganui the previous Saturday, when Marion and Tom Waterland set out to follow the old route carrying 300 specially-franked letters.

The letters were carried up the Wanganui River by paddle steamer to Pipiriki, then transported by horse and carriage and vintage car to Tokaanu.

As part of the re-enactment carrier pigeons were released from the Alice as she headed towards Taupo.

In the "olden days" the pigeons were released soon after the ferryboats left Tokaanu, advising the staff at the former Terraces Hotel (now De Bretts) how many guests were on board requiring accommodation.

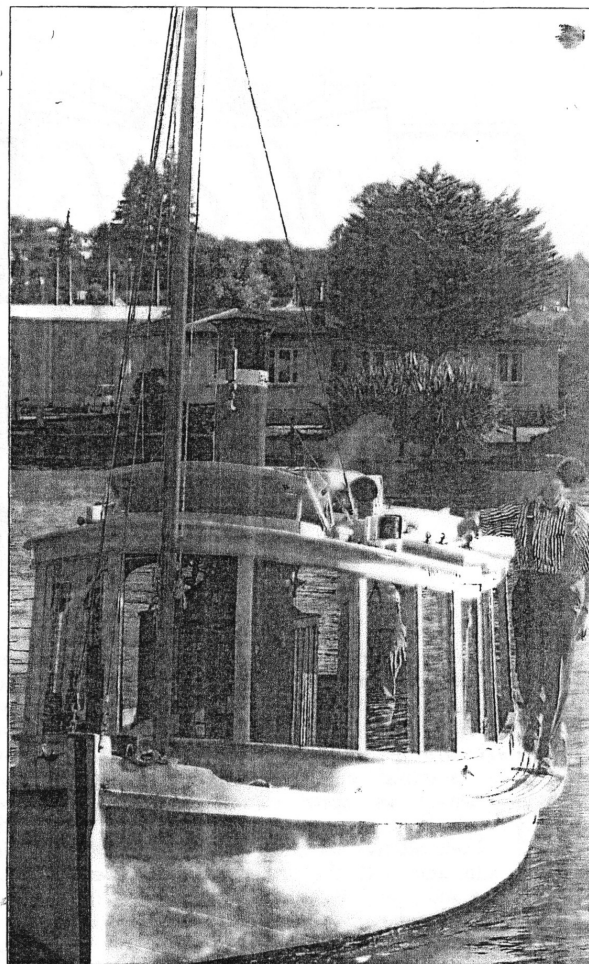


HISTORIC HORSEPOWER: Arthur Saunders and Marian Waterland head up the Napier-Taupo Highway where they will hand over the mail sack for the last leg of its journey.

The next stage of the re-enactment on Saturday saw the mail brought into Taupo boat harbour, where it was uplifted by horse and cart and taken to De Bretts.

There, Deputy Mayor Christine McElwee added another piece of mail to the letter bag, sending greetings to Napier Mayor Neil Taylor.

The last leg of the heritage run saw the mail bag carried to Napier in a vintage motorcycle and sidecar, accompanied by 36 motorcyclists from the Hawke's Bay Classic Motorcycle Club.



OFFICIAL CARGO: The steamship Alice comes into berth after re-enacting the Tokaanu to Taupo leg of the mail run.



SPECIAL DELIVERY: Alan Grime and passenger Ted Billett of the Hawke's Bay Classic Motorcycle Club were among 36 motorcyclists from the club to escort 300 specially franked letters from Taupo to Napier on Saturday.

The motorcyclists carried the letters on the last leg of their six-day journey, a re-enactment of a historic mail run that took 19th century postmen three weeks.

The postal run began in Wanganui at midday last Saturday, when steam enthusiasts Marion and Tom Waterland of Taupo set out to follow the Napier mail run that was in operation from about 1875 to 1924.

The letters were carried up the Wanganui River by the paddle-steamer Waimarie to Pipiriki, where they were driven by horse and cart and vintage car to Tokaanu.

The 123-year-old steam boat Alice then took 4½ hours to take the mail across Lake Taupo.

As part of the re-enactment, carrier pigeons — once used to relay messages regarding the number of guests ahead to their hotel in Taupo — were released. At the Taupo marina, the mail was collected by a horse and trap, which took it to De Bretts Hotel, where motorcycle club

members met the bags and took them to Napier.

Club member and co-organiser Barry Lay said it was the 13th year the club had been involved in the run, which was a good opportunity to give the pre-1950s bikes an airing.

Mr Lay said it was the first time the re-enactment had included the Wanganui section, coinciding with Wanganui's heritage weekend.

BILL KEARNS